



TRIGUNAS

The Three Qualities of Existence

Sattva, Rajas, and Tamas are the three fundamental gunas present in every conscious and material element at all times.



The Threads of Reality

The word Guna literally translates to thread. According to Panini's Dhatu-patha, these three fundamental qualities weave together to create the fabric of reality.

The gunas are not sequential; they operate simultaneously. Only their proportion varies from moment to moment.

The Physics of Balance

To stay in a chosen lane on a banked track, three forces must cooperate. Braking is inertia, pedaling is activity, and staying on course is balance. All three elements must operate simultaneously to keep the cyclist upright.



Pedaling (*Activity*) → RAJAS
Too fast, you slide out.

Staying on Course (*Balance*) → SATTVA

Braking (*Inertia*) → TAMAS
Too slow, you drift in.

SATTVA	RAJAS	TAMAS
	<i>Fundamental Nature</i>	
Tendency toward balance	Tendency toward activity	Tendency toward inertia
	<i>Psychological State</i>	
Joyful, light, illuminated thought	Driven, energized, motivated	Lethargic, heavy, resistant
	<i>Cosmic Function</i>	
Preservation	Creation	Dissolution
	<i>Practical Outcome</i>	
Correct discernment & decisions	Initiation of action (aggressive/defensive)	Rest & unmanifestation



Sattva — The Light of Discernment

Sattva is the tendency toward perfect balance. When Sattva predominates, the mind feels uniquely light and joyful.

The power of thought is illuminated. This is the precise state in which correct decisions are made and reality is seen clearly.



Rajas — The Drive of Activity

Rajas provides the vital energy for creation, initiation, and motivation. It is the fuel for action.

The Ten-Minute Warning.

You have ten minutes to catch a departing bus. In such adverse or urgent moments, a sudden surge of Rajas is literally life-saving, providing the exact energy needed for aggressive or defensive action.

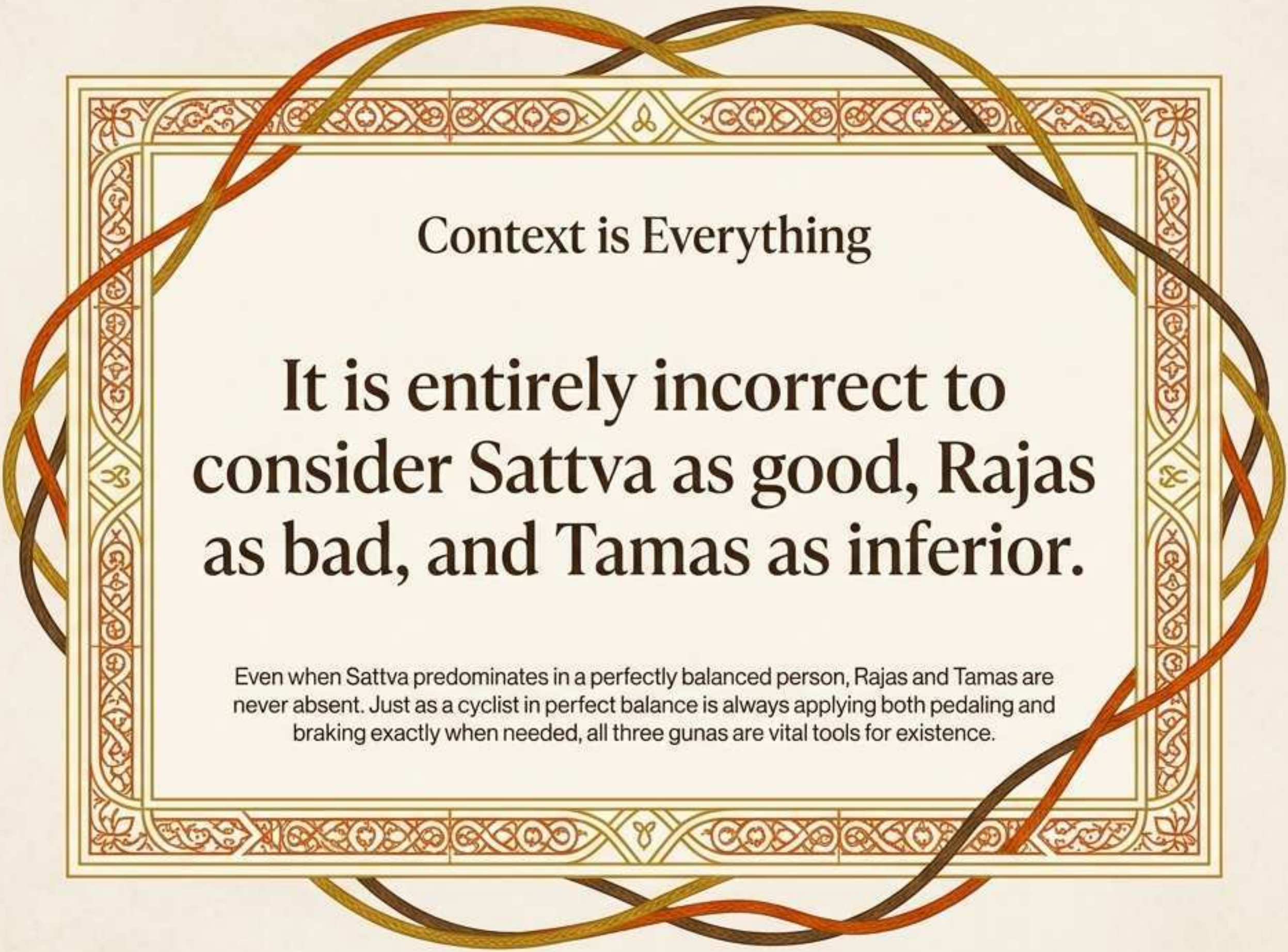


Tamas — The Anchor of Rest

Tamas is the tendency toward inertia, heaviness, and darkness. While often misunderstood as negative, it is the energy of necessary resistance.

The Fresh Day.

The characteristics of Tamas are highly desirable in the state of sleep.
A fresh, new day requires sound, heavy sleep to reset the system.
Tamas performs the exact right function at the exact right time.



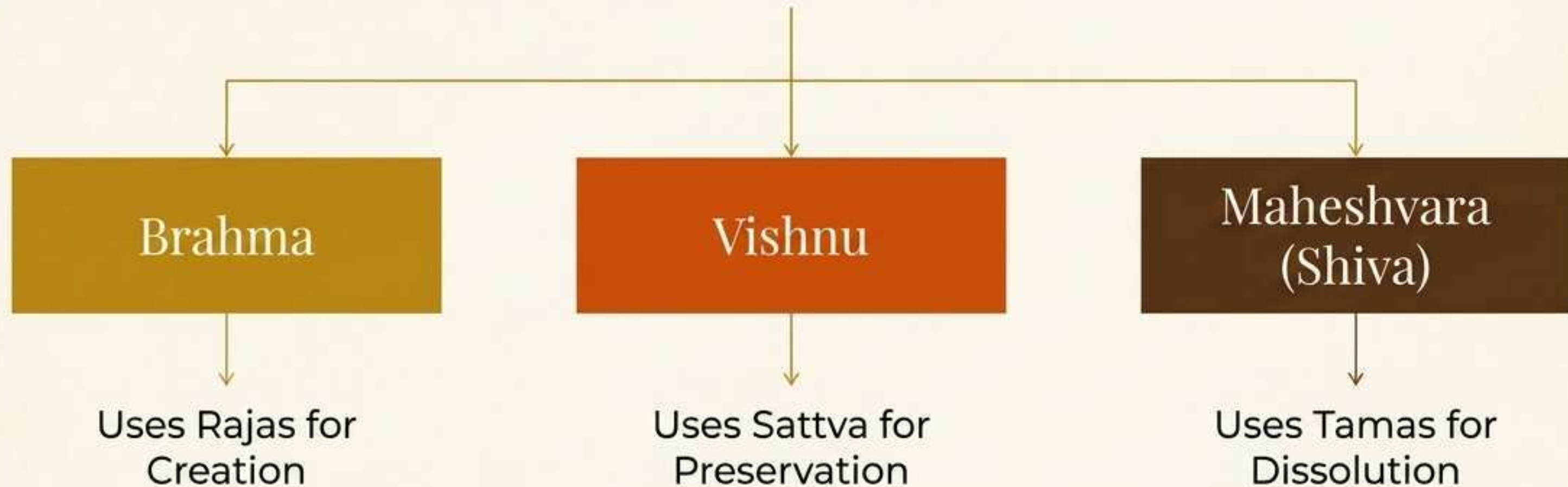
Context is Everything

It is entirely incorrect to consider Sattva as good, Rajas as bad, and Tamas as inferior.

Even when Sattva predominates in a perfectly balanced person, Rajas and Tamas are never absent. Just as a cyclist in perfect balance is always applying both pedaling and braking exactly when needed, all three gunas are vital tools for existence.

The Cosmic Scale: The Trimurti

The ultimate forces of the universe—Creation, Preservation, and Dissolution—are carried out by utilizing these specific gunas.



Crucial Distinction: The Trimurti are not conquered by these powers; rather, they utilize them as cosmic instruments.

Visualizing Function Through Form



Tamas/Shiva

His function is unmanifestation and dissolution. Therefore, his form is an ascetic yogi—entirely removed from the world's wealth.

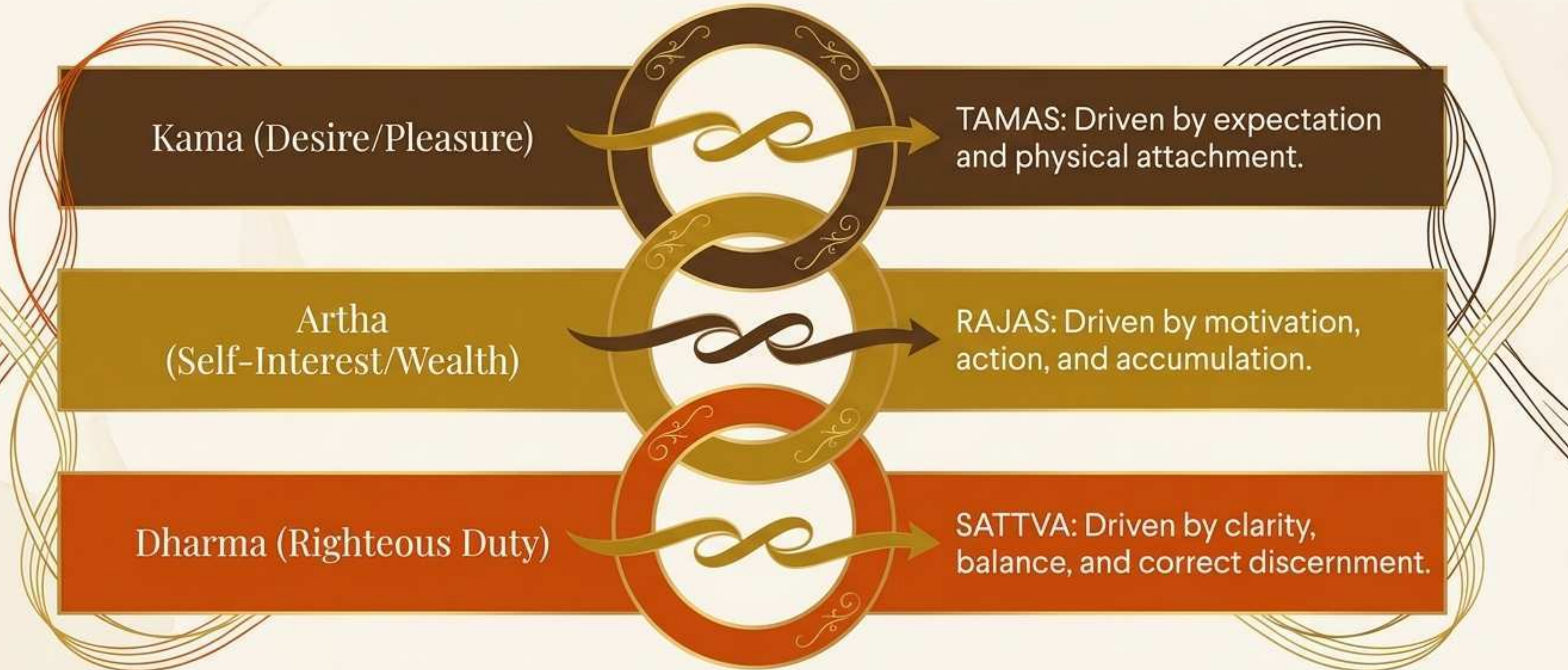


Sattva/Vishnu

His function is preservation. To preserve the world, he must actively participate in the world of senses. Therefore, he is adorned in splendid clothes and draped in golden silk garments.

Aligning Action and Energy

According to Manusmriti (12.38), specific gunas are the underlying characteristics of specific life pursuits:



Observe Your Own Gunas

1
When you wake up tomorrow, observe the first hour. Which guna predominated? At what exact moment did it shift, and what caused the shift?

2
Consider your daily states—sleep, work, meditation, play, anger. Make a list. Which guna is most appropriate and necessary for each state?

3
Dharma requires Sattva. What specific activity in your life demands a highly sattvic state, and how do you intentionally create it?



Balance



Activity

Rest

The Endless Cycle

- ✓ All three gunas operate continuously in all things at all times.
- ✓ Balance (Sattva), Action (Rajas), and Rest (Tamas) are equally necessary for a functioning system.
- ✓ True mastery lies not in eliminating any quality, but in applying the right guna to the right context.